

Family money depends on family culture. And family culture depends on family members—old and young. Having a family culture that supports wealth generation and preservation is another secret of Old Money.

For example, Old Money families embrace production over consumption. This becomes part of their culture, their identity as individuals and as a family. Successful multigenerational families spend a lot of time developing a family culture that encourages production and discourages consumption. This becomes a kind of shared family value, another form of “glue” that helps hold your family together.

Of course, this culture has to be real. It can be developed and embellished. But it can’t be made up. And it has to be relevant to new generations. So it must build on family traditions and be dynamic and flexible at the same time.

Another way of looking at this is that the Old Money family needs to stay as “outsiders.” It has to remain apart—to some extent—from the culture of the masses, or even of the rich.

Your family’s culture is not something you can easily define. But that doesn’t make it unimportant. Let’s look at some of the elements.

FAMILY VALUES

These are the social and moral beliefs that are important to your family (not the politicized “family values” you hear so much about). Although you may hold many such values in common with other families, there will be some that seem unique to your family. And the way you go about expressing those values may also be unique to your family.

Take, for example, the family business. If your family is involved in a business, it will be a major component of your family’s culture. Your family should hold in high regard the unique skills and secrets that make it work. You should also teach these skills and insights to the next generation as a right of passage.

One thing to avoid: It is typical in modern America for people to mock or denigrate a business, its customers, and its products. The sophisticated ironist feels uneasy with the earnest efforts required in a business—